

INDIAN SOCIETY — PART 2

Anthropology Optional Foundation | Paper 2 (Ch. 3.1 & 3.2) | Sarathi IAS — Nataraj Sir

UPSC CSE 2026 — EXAM-READY COMPREHENSIVE NOTES

INDIAN SOCIETY — HANDOUT 2

**RACIAL
CLASSIFICATION**
Risley, Guha, Sarkar

PURUSHARTHA
Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha

VARNASHRAMA
4 Varnas x 4 Ashramas

**REBIRTH &
REBIRTH**
4 Debts + Samsara cycle

KARMA
Action, Fate vs Agency

**CASTE
SYSTEM**
Ghurye, Dumont, Varna vs Jati

1. CLASSIFICATION OF INDIAN POPULATION

Scholar	Method	Key Types	Strengths	Weaknesses
Risley (1915)	Anthropometry (body measurements — head, nose)	7 types under 3 groups: Dravidian, Indo-Aryan, Mongolian	First systematic attempt in India; described Rajputs, Pathans, Marathas; showed link between race, caste, region	Scytho-Dravidian / Mongolo-Dravidian labels criticised; didn't recognise tribals separately; Haddon : oldest stratum = pre-Dravidian jungle tribes
B.S. Guha (1931)	Anthropometric data from 1931 Census	6 divisions: Negrito, Proto-Australoid, Mongoloid, Mediterranean, Western Brachycephals, Nordic	More data-based; widely used baseline; linked racial types with census data; called India "paradise of diversification"	Sarkar found no Negrito traits among Kaders; overstated brachycephalisation; method (coefficient of racial likelihood) not universally accepted
S.S. Sarkar (1954)	Cephalic index (head breadth-to-length ratio)	6 elements: Australoid, Indo-Aryan, Irano-Scythian, Mundari, Far Eastern, Mongolian	More precise head measurements; India mainly dolichocephalic (long-headed); corrected Guha — denied Negrito; added Irano-Scythian & Far Eastern	Still stuck in racial typology while anthropology was moving to population genetics ; narrow focus on cephalic index; not widely adopted outside India

Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

These classifications represent early attempts at understanding India's biological diversity. Modern anthropology has moved from **racial typology to population genetics** (DNA-based studies), rendering rigid racial categories obsolete. However, these studies remain important for understanding how colonial-era racial theories influenced caste ideology (e.g., Risley linking race to caste) and continue to impact social policy debates around reservation and identity politics. The shift from phenotypic classification to genomic analysis (e.g., Reich et al. 2009 on ANI-ASI admixture) represents the field's evolution.

2. PURUSHARTHA — The Fourfold Path of Life (Ch. 3.1)

Literal meaning: "Object of human pursuit" — a four-fold path of life: Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha. Purushartha provides the principles of the Indian ethical system. Of these four, **Dharma is central** to all human activities and allows the right satisfaction of desires.

A. DHARMA — The Central Pillar

P.V. Kane — Four Dimensions of Dharma:

1. Rights & duties of a man as a man | 2. Duties as a member of the Aryan community | 3. Special duties, rights & functions as a society member | 4. Obligations in the changing stations of life

Dharma vs Religion — Key Contrast

Aspect	Dharma (Wider)	Religion (Narrower)
Nature	Duty, righteousness, moral law — sustains individual & society	System of faith, belief, worship, rituals tied to a community
Scope	Eternal, universal (<i>Sanatana Dharma</i>), action-oriented: "What is right to do here and now?"	Can vary by time/place; often emphasizes external practice
Focus	Inner compass — combines law, ethics, duty, cosmic order	May harden into ritualism, dogma, or external identity
Essence	Timeless & universal — preserved above all else; heaven can be lost, but dharma cannot be abandoned	Religion may change across cultures; focuses on scriptures/rituals

Radhakrishnan:

"Dharma is not mere belief, but a principle of right living that directs human destiny."

Wilhelm Halbfass:

Dharma cannot be translated as "religion" — it is wider, combining law, ethics, duty, and cosmic order.

Dharma Across Traditions

Tradition	Dharma Teaching	Key Points
Hinduism	Dharma guides Artha & Kama, paves way for Moksha	Yudhishtira-dog story: refused to abandon dog (symbol of dharma) even for heaven — dharma > religious reward. Hinduism sees dharma as higher than ritual religion
Buddhism	Dhamma — universal law of righteousness	Ethical conduct & compassion > ritual; Four Noble Truths + Eightfold Path are dharmic, not dogmatic. Max Weber: made ethics center of practice
Jainism	Dharma = Ahimsa (non-violence)	<i>Das-dharma</i> (10 virtues): forgiveness, humility, truth, renunciation; practice ahimsa = follow true dharma. Highly ethical & reformist movement against rigid ritualism

Case Study: Yudhishtira and the Dog (Mahabharata)

When offered heaven, Yudhishtira refuses to abandon the dog (symbol of dharma/loyalty). Shows: **dharm**a must be upheld even above religious reward. "Heaven can be lost, but dharma cannot be abandoned." Buddhism & Jainism also confirm: true spiritual progress lies in dharma — ethical living, not just religious form.

B. ARTHA, KAMA & MOKSHA

Purushartha	Meaning	Key Details
ARTHA	Non-greedy acquisition of wealth & power through righteous manner	Wealth = means to an end, NOT an end itself; necessary only to fulfill dharmic social obligations. Kautilya (Arthashastra) : wealth only when it serves larger social good — echoes ESG, CSR
KAMA	All desires in man — impulses, instincts	Wrongly conceived as only bodily desires. Corrective balance between body & mind needed. Contemporary : links with mental health rights, gender equality, LGBTQ+ rights, responsible digital use
MOKSHA	Liberation from endless cycle of life & death (samsara)	Also called <i>mukti</i> ; from Sanskrit <i>muc</i> ("to free"); absorption of self into eternal bliss. N.A. Nikam : proper analogy = "a river joining the ocean" (Upanishads)

Paths to Moksha — Trimarga (Bhagavad Gita)

Yoga	Path	Description
Karma Yoga	Path of Action	Selfless action without attachment to fruits
Bhakti Yoga	Path of Devotion	Devotion to Ishvar (God)
Jnana Yoga	Path of Knowledge	Self-realization through wisdom
Raja Yoga	Path of Meditation	Dhyana Marga — making "Four Yogas" / "Four paths to realization"

Three principal motivating forces: Dharma, Artha, and Kama are the three principal urges around which the whole life conduct of man is comprehended. Management and conduct of individual and social life is conceived and formulated in terms of these three with reference to the ultimate end/goal of life — i.e., **Moksha**.

Ethical & Philosophical Basis + Contemporary Relevance

Principle	Classical Basis	Contemporary Relevance
Integration of material & spiritual	Balances Kama, Artha, Dharma, Moksha; prevents one-sided development (Radhakrishnan)	Work-life balance; holistic well-being; value education
Primacy of Dharma	Without Dharma, Artha → greed, Kama → indulgence	Ethical governance; anti-corruption; SC judgments on equality; climate activism (Greta Thunberg)
Teleological vision	Life has direction & purpose; Moksha = final release; other three are preparatory	Debates: Is pursuing justice, equality, rights a more immediate form of liberation?
Quest for inner freedom	Moksha = transcendence	Mindfulness, yoga, spiritual tourism; burnout, consumerism → search for meaning beyond material success
Public service frame	Purushartha = moral compass for civil servants	Dharma (justice) Artha (resource mgmt) Kama (human welfare) Moksha (personal integrity)
Global parallels	Deva Rina (debt to nature)	SDGs echo Purushartha: ethics, prosperity, well-being, long-term balance; climate justice

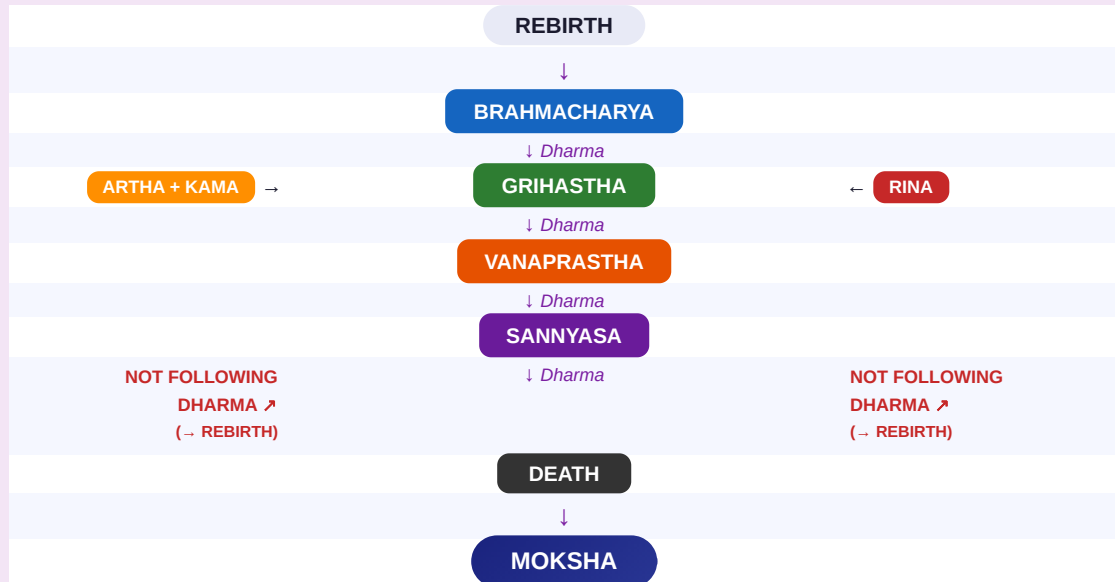
Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

Purushartha represents one of humanity's earliest frameworks for **integrating individual desire with social obligation**. Anthropologically, it shows how pre-modern societies created normative systems that balanced material & spiritual needs — unlike Western individualism which separates the two. Its framework parallels **Maslow's hierarchy of needs** (physiological → self-actualization). In contemporary India, Purushartha informs constitutional values (Dharma → justice), economic policy (Artha → welfare state), personal rights (Kama → gender/LGBTQ+), and spiritual movements (Moksha → yoga/mindfulness). For UPSC: frame it as India's indigenous ethical system with continuing relevance to governance, social justice & global frameworks like SDGs.

3. VARNASHRAMA DHARMA — The Ashram System (Ch. 3.1)

Hindu philosophy developed two great organizing frameworks: **Varna** (social division of duties: Brahmin/Kshatriya/Vaishya/Shudra) and **Ashrama** (life stages: Student/Householder/Retiree/Renunciate). Together = **Varnasrama Dharma**: "What is one's duty, according to one's role in society and one's stage of life" — both a **social code** and a **spiritual framework**.

ASHRAM LIFECYCLE FLOW (from class diagram)



Class note: "Shouldn't it be like this??" — student questioned whether the REBIRTH branch should connect back differently when dharma is NOT followed at ANY stage (not just at the end)

The Four Ashramas — Detailed Breakdown

Ashrama	Focus & Duties	By Varna	Key Example
1. Brahmacharya (Student)	Dharma — attain knowledge to fulfill dharma for rest of life; piety, self-denial, discipline; non-indulgence in Artha/Kama	Brahmin: Vedas, sciences, philosophy under guru Kshatriya: warfare, archery, administration, leadership Vaishya: agriculture, trade, animal-rearing Shudra: crafts, service skills, preserving dignity through honest work	Nachiketa — refused wealth & pleasures, insisted on knowledge of truth (ideal Brahmachari)
2. Grihastha (Householder) MOST CRUCIAL	Artha + Kama under Dharma; initiated through vivah (marriage); stage of full bliss & blessings; duties: reproduction, wealth acquisition, education, helping society. Sustains ALL other Ashramas through wealth, taxes, hospitality	Brahmin: teach, guide society ethically, perform rituals Kshatriya: protect, rule justly, ensure security Vaishya: earn through honest trade & agriculture, feed society Shudra: provide service, maintain cultural arts & crafts	Householder = hub of all Rina repayment: feeds guests (Atithi), cares for parents (Pitra), supports teachers (Rishi), offerings to gods (Deva)
3. Vanaprastha (Retirement)	Transition from Artha/Kama → Moksha ; devotes time to religious pursuits; retire into forest, meditation with minimal needs; hands over responsibilities to next generation; advisory role; preparatory to ultimate retirement ; NOT totally detached from world	Brahmin: withdraw to forests, meditate, write, selectively teach Kshatriya: hand over kingdom to heirs Vaishya: retire from business, focus on charity, live simply Shudra: withdraw from labor, pass on skills	Dhritarashtra & Gandhari — after the war, retired to forest and lived in meditation
4. Sannyasa (Renunciation)	Total detachment ; links with family completely cut off; no more a member of society ; complete renunciation of material desires; state of disinterest from material life; without property or home (Ascetic); focused on Moksha , peace & simple spiritual life	Brahmin: renounce ties, wander as ascetic Kshatriya: lay down arms & crown, embrace peace Vaishya: leave wealth, live detached Shudra: devote life to prayer & spirituality	Yudhishtira — renounced throne, journeyed to Himalayas; attained liberation by refusing to abandon dharma (dog)

- ### What Varnashrama Ensured

 - Social harmony** — assigning duties according to Varna
 - Personal discipline** — dividing life into stages of responsibility & detachment
 - Spiritual purpose** — keeping Moksha as the final aim
 - "Varna tells you *WHAT* to do, Ashrama tells you *WHEN* to do it"

Interrelation: Ashrama x Purushartha + Modern Link

Ashrama	Focus	Today
Brahmacharya	Dharma: learning, discipline	NEP 2020 — ethics education; character building
Grihastha	Artha & Kama under Dharma	Work-life balance, consumerism debates, responsible parenting
Vanaprastha	Gradual detachment → Moksha	Retirement planning, volunteering, community service
Sannyasa	Moksha only	Minimalism, spiritual retreats, eco-conscious lifestyles

Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

Varnashrama is an example of how traditional societies created **age-graded social institutions** — comparable to Van Gennep's rites of passage and Erikson's psychosocial stages. Anthropologically, it served as a **mechanism of social control and cultural reproduction**. **Critique (Ambedkar)**: Varna tied duties to birth rather than choice, becoming justification for hereditary hierarchies. Modern relevance: the life-stage wisdom translates into value education, sustainable business (CSR/ESG = Artha under Dharma), and eco-conscious living. Varnashrama still matters when reinterpreted as a guide for ethical duty, social responsibility, and spiritual growth — without the rigidity of birth-based varna.

4. RINA (DEBT) & REBIRTH (Ch. 3.1)

Core Concept of Rina

- Debts = **expression of gratitude** for gifts received from the world — **not meant to be a burden**
- Taking from the world without giving back → **additional karmic bondage**
- Every Hindu is **born with debt** — obliged to repay to achieve salvation; failure → endless cycle of birth & death
- Born indebted to: ancestors (lineage), parents (upbringing), community & culture, gods & sages, nature at large

Bhagavad Gita:

"Evil is his being, sensuous is his delight, in vain, O Partha, that man lives." (condemns those who consume without giving back)

Types of Rina — Detailed

Type	Debt To	How Repaid	Modern Parallel
Deva Rina	God / Nature	Prayer, sacrifices, yagnas, conservation — leaving world better than received	Planting trees, environmental conservation
Rishi Rina	Guru / Sages	Learning, propagating wisdom, adding to knowledge; guru dakshina	Volunteering in education, knowledge sharing
Pitra Rina	Parents / Ancestors	Continuing lineage through procreation; customs like pind daan	Organ donation (giving life), intergenerational care
Atithi Rina	Guests	Showing remembrance and serving them	Supporting refugees; COVID community kitchens

The Rina Cycle

BORN IN DEBT → Spends entire life repaying = **DHARMA**



Done dutifully without expectations → Liberated from all debts = **MOKSHA**

Done half-heartedly/conditionally → Entrapped in web of **KARMA** → **REBORN** with burden of debt

Western vs Indian Model of Debt

WESTERN MODEL

- Not born in debt** — owe nothing until successful/rich
- Based on Abrahamic concepts: **zakat** (Islam), **tithe** (Christianity)
- Freedom from obligation is the default

INDIC MODEL

- Born with debt** to family, culture, nature by virtue of being alive
- Based on **Rinna** — lifelong obligations
- No escape** from karmic cycle until all debts repaid

Deeper Link: Varnashrama x Rina (7 Connections)

#	Link	Key Point
1	Duties = moral debts	Varnashrama tells WHAT & WHEN; Rina explains WHY. Kane : Dharma = not just rules but recognition of obligations. A Brahmin who teaches, a Kshatriya who protects = repaying debts
2	Grihastha = hub of repayment	Feeding guests (Atithi), caring for parents (Pitra), supporting teachers (Rishi), offerings to gods (Deva) — all in householder stage
3	Liberation through responsibility	Fulfilling Rina sincerely = stepping stone to Moksha; neglect → rebirth. Parallels climate justice — developed nations owe "climate debt" to Global South
4	Gratitude & interdependence	Arvind Sharma : Hindu thought placed duties at heart of ethics (vs Western rights-focus). India's SC frames rights within duties
5	Critiques	Ambedkar : Varna tied duties to birth → justified hereditary hierarchies. Feminists : If debts central, why is women's unpaid labor not recognized?
6	Modern civic life	COVID-19: frontline workers = Rishi Rina; community kitchens = Atithi Rina. Organ donation = Pitra Rina. Tree planting = Deva Rina
7	Time-bound vs Timeless	Ashrama = temporal (stages); Rina = eternal (debts lifelong). Even a renunciate is bound to Deva Rina (meditation) & Rishi Rina (passing wisdom)

Rebirth — Concept & Debates

- Soul returns in new body/form, influenced by **karma** of past life
- Every human has an **everlasting and imperishable soul** — persists even when body destroyed
- **Origin:** First mentioned in **Satapatha Brahmana** ; linkage with karma = post-Vedic development
- **Samkhya tradition:** If disciple stays → **super conscious ecstasy**; if leaves → **nirvikalpa samadhi**
- End goal of yoga = moksha. Not everyone can attain it — only a true sanyasi can claim it
- Because karma is tied to rebirth, those who follow dharma will have a better and more successful life

Perspective	View on Rebirth
Classical Hindu	Unpaid debts → soul returns; linked to <i>samsara</i>
Buddhism	Rebirth without permanent soul (<i>anatman</i>) — karmic continuity, not fixed self
Jainism	Karma through passions & violence; <i>ahimsa</i> = way to cut cycle
Advaita Vedanta	Samsara = ignorance-driven illusion (<i>maya</i>)
Nyaya-Vaisheshika	Rebirth as concrete causal process of karma
N.A. Nikam	Rebirth = not just punishment but opportunity — another chance to progress
Vivekananda	Reframed as symbolic of moral accountability
Ambedkar	Rejected — reinforces caste oppression; "debts of birth" justified hierarchy
Ian Stevenson	Studies on past-life memories (contested) kept discussion alive
Contemporary	Unfulfilled obligations return as crises for next generation. Climate change = "rebirth" of neglected debts

Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

Rina represents a **duty-centered moral framework** — in contrast to the rights-based Western model. Anthropologically, it shows how traditional societies embedded reciprocity and intergenerational obligation into social structure (cf. Mauss's "The Gift"). The concept of being born in debt creates a web of **social solidarity** — but also perpetuates hierarchy when tied to birth (Ambedkar's critique). Rebirth doctrine serves as a theodicy (explaining suffering) and mechanism of social control. Contemporary relevance: climate debt, intergenerational justice, COVID-era community response, feminist critique of unpaid care labor. For UPSC: contrast with rights-based frameworks; link to SDGs and climate justice.

5. KARMA — Action, Work, Deed (Ch. 3.1)

Karma = every action has consequences. It makes a person **accountable for his own actions**. One's current state = outcome of actions of previous and present life. The concept of karma is **tied to the concept of rebirth**.

Interpretations of Karma

Scholar	Interpretation
N.A. Nikam	<i>Artha-kriya-karitra</i> — good actions produce good effects instantaneously and bad actions produce bad effects instantaneously
S. Radhakrishnan	"There is no doctrine so valuable in life and conduct as the karma theory — it implies hope for the future and resignation of the past"
Wilhelm Halbfass	Good intent + good deeds → good karma + happier rebirths; bad intent + bad deeds → bad karma + bad rebirths
Natural Science	Man is product of evolution; karma asks man to "take conscious charge of his adventure" — whatever the past, the future is new

Significance of Karma

- Instills **morality** — people realize they are accountable for deeds
- Inspires good actions not only for a better future life but a **more just present**
- Unlike fatalism, karma is **rational**, encouraging conscious choices over passive acceptance

Is Karma Fatalistic? — The Great Debate

KARMA AS FATALISM (Critics)

- Max Weber (1958)**: Karma & rebirth = "closed social system" — people accepted their place, discouraging social change
- Louis Dumont (1970)**: Karma = ideological basis of caste hierarchy; birth status justified by previous karma, making inequality appear divinely ordained

KARMA AS EMPOWERMENT (Counter)

- Radhakrishnan (1937)**: Not deterministic; present choices shape future
- Vivekananda**: "Man is maker of his destiny; each action plants a seed"
- P.V. Kane**: Tied to Dharma — gives agency to act rightly in present

Key Distinction: *Fatalism* = everything is fixed → resignation | *Karma* = actions have consequences → individuals are **responsible** for shaping their lives

Nishkama Karma — The Gita's Ideal

Krishna to Arjuna (Bhagavad Gita, Ch. 2, Verse 47):

"To action alone hast thou a right, never at all to its fruits; let not the fruits of action be thy motive, nor let there be in thee any attachment to inaction."

- Nishkama Karma Yoga** = yoga of **selfless action**
- Actions performed **without expectation of fruits**
- Purifies the mind → prepares for higher wisdom
- Way to liberation = not escape from action, but **action without attachment**

Karma, Rebirth & the Four Purusharthas

Purushartha	Karma Impact	Example
Dharma	Righteous conduct → karma becomes <i>punya</i> → higher rebirth or liberation	Earning wealth honestly, raising family with love, speaking truth
Artha	If gained through <i>adharma</i> → negative karma + bondage; if gained ethically & used for service → positive karma. Both opportunity & risk	Corruption/greed → binds soul; charity & society support → positive karma
Kama	Within Dharma (marriage, family) → good karma; without Dharma (lust, exploitation) → negative karma + lower rebirths. Not condemned, but must be guided by Dharma	Marriage, companionship → sustains society; selfishness → negative karma
Moksha	Ultimate goal: transcend karma & rebirth cycle. Living with Dharma + moderating Artha & Kama → soul breaks free = no more rebirth, union with Brahman	As Radhakrishnan said: karma is "self-determined destiny, not blind fate"

Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

Karma is one of the most powerful **theodicies** (explanations for suffering) in world religions. Anthropologically, it functions as a **mechanism of social regulation** — encouraging ethical behavior through belief in cosmic consequences. **Weber's critique** (fatalism/closed system) and **Dumont's analysis** (ideological basis of hierarchy) show how karma supported caste stratification. But **Radhakrishnan/Vivekananda's counter** demonstrates its empowering dimension — personal agency and moral responsibility. Nishkama Karma anticipates modern concepts of **intrinsic motivation** and duty-based ethics (cf. Kant's categorical imperative). Contemporary relevance: ethical governance, CSR, environmental responsibility. For UPSC: always present both sides (fatalism vs empowerment) and link to contemporary social change.

6. CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM (Ch. 3.2)

Definitions & Etymology

Kroeber (1930):

"Caste is an endogamous and hereditary subdivision of an ethnic unit occupying a position of superior or inferior rank or social esteem."

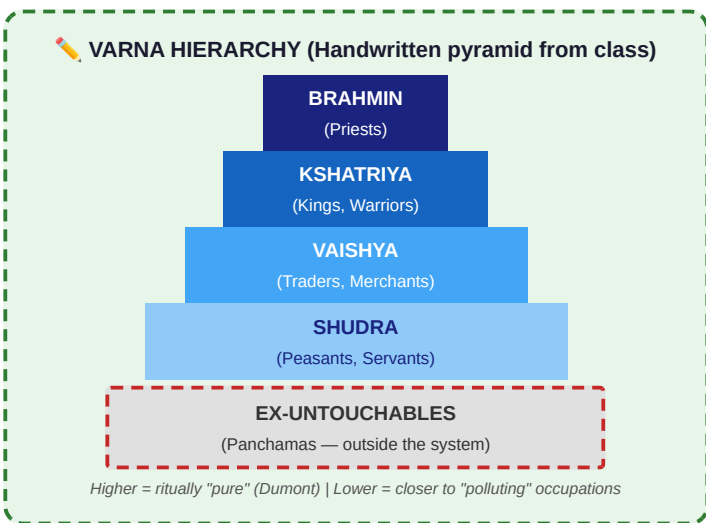
G.S. Ghurye (1932):

"Any attempt at definition is bound to fail because of the complexity of the phenomenon."

- 'Caste' from Portuguese "**casta**" = pure breed
- Two Indian terms: **Varna** (colour; 4-fold division) and **Jati** (birth-based group)
- Those excluded from 4 Varnas = **Panchamas / fifth category** (outcastes, foreigners, slaves, conquered peoples)
- Caste is an ancient social institution that has been part of Indian history and culture for **thousands of years**
- Uniquely associated with the Indian subcontinent; while similar effects have existed elsewhere, the exact form has not been found outside India
- Although characteristic of Hindu society, caste has spread to major non-Hindu communities of the Indian sub-continent

Varna vs Jati (Caste)

Category	Jati (Caste)	Varna
Meaning	Social group based on birth	Class system based on occupation
Origin	Developed over time through social stratification	Described in ancient Hindu texts as 4-fold division
Number	Thousands — vary by region & religion	Four: Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra
Mobility	Little to no social mobility	Theoretically can move based on occupation & behavior
Scope	Regional/local sub-classification	Broad all-India aggregative classification
Discrimination	Common feature	Theoretically not discriminatory but used to justify it
Relevance	Still significant despite being officially outlawed	Largely superseded by caste in practice



Varna & Buddhism / Jainism — Reform Movements

Aspect	Buddhism	Jainism
Origin	6th c. BCE, Second Urbanisation — rejected Varna hierarchy	Same period — rejected Brahmanical ritualism & Varna; classified among <i>sramana</i> traditions
Teaching	Karma & intention (<i>cetana</i>) = basis of moral worth, not birth. <i>Vasala Sutta</i> : "By action one becomes a Brahmin or an outcaste." Democratized access to Nirvana via Eightfold Path, not ritual sacrifices	Fundamental equality of all living beings (<i>jiva</i>); ahimsa = path to liberation for all regardless of caste. Five vows (<i>mahavratas</i>): ahimsa, satya, asteya, brahmacharya, aparigraha
Scholars	Romila Thapar : product of & reaction to Varna. Gail Omvedt : opened new moral order. Bronkhorst (2011) : weakened ritual economy placing Brahmins at top	Paul Dundas : liberation for all regardless of caste/gender. Padmanabh Jaini : ethics → personal discipline. Hermann Jacobi : challenged Brahmanical orthodoxy
Appeal	Inclusive; used Pali (local language); attracted marginalized castes; Ambedkar : "religion of social equality." Sanchi & Bharhut inscriptions show non-elite patronage	Attractive in mercantile communities — spiritual justification for restraint & honest trade. Anekantavada (many-sidedness of truth) fostered intellectual pluralism
Influence	Denied Brahmins were sole custodians of sacred knowledge; democratized spiritual liberation	Shaped vegetarianism, Gandhian non-violence (<i>satyagraha</i>). Paradox : egalitarian theology but caste-like structures adopted in practice

G.S. Ghurye's Six Defining Features of Caste (1932)

#	Feature	Description	#	Feature	Description
1	Segmentation by birth	Membership determined by birth ; hereditary; one inherits caste identity	4	Feeding & social restrictions	Minute rules on food/drink upper castes could accept from lower; lower castes generally accepted food from upper
2	Endogamy	Restrictions on marrying outside caste; hypergamy allowed sometimes; sub-caste endogamy = principal feature	5	Hereditary occupation	Lack of unrestricted choice of profession; caste members restricted from "degrading" professions
3	Hierarchical system	Generally Brahmins at head; disputed in some cases; hundreds of castes with gradation acknowledged by everyone	6	Segregation	Dominant caste in center, others on periphery; restrictions on water wells, streets by one caste on another

Limitations: Relied on colonial census reports & **H.H. Risley's** racist theories (1901 Census Commissioner). **Graham Chapman**: difference between theoretical constructs of caste & practical reality.

Louis Dumont — Caste & Hierarchy (*Homo Hierarchicus*, 1970)

Concept	Explanation	Concept	Explanation
Purity-Pollution	Ritual rankings based on purity & pollution ; closer to sacred = pure = high; distant = polluting = low	Division of Labour	Caste linked with occupation → functions as social division of labour ; in principle, allows no mobility
Holism & Hierarchy	Caste = difference/separation + holism/hierarchy ; each caste exists only in relation to totality	Power & Status	Material power closely associated with social status; defeated in wars → often assigned low caste status
Complementarity	Castes are unequal but complementary & non-competing ; each has its own place	Ordered Rank	Each caste occupies a particular position in a ladder-like arrangement from highest to lowest

How Caste Worked in Practice + Age of the System

- Upper/lower castes lived in **segregated colonies**; water wells not shared
- Brahmins wouldn't accept food from Shudras; could only **marry within one's caste**
- System bestowed privileges on upper castes while sanctioning **repression** of lower castes
- Criticised for being **unjust & regressive** — trapping people into fixed social orders
- Despite obstacles: **BR Ambedkar** (authored Constitution) and **KR Narayanan** (first Dalit president) rose to prominence

Period	Nature
Vedic (900–500 BCE)	4 varnas; divisions were relatively flexible with scope for mobility
Post-Vedic	Varna → rigid caste structure ; occupations & status became fixed & hereditary
Overall age	Around 3,000 years ; nature has evolved over time

- Historians note: until 18th Century, formal distinctions were of limited importance — social identities were more **flexible**

Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

Caste is the **most studied system of social stratification** in anthropology. Ghurye's 6 features remain the standard framework; Dumont's purity-pollution model is both influential and contested. Anthropologically, caste functions as a system of **social closure** (Weber), **ritual hierarchy** (Dumont), and **economic exploitation** (Marxist view). Buddhism & Jainism represent early **counter-hegemonic movements** that challenged birth-based hierarchy with conduct-based ethics. Contemporary relevance: caste persists in marriage, politics (reservation), and urban discrimination (Thorat & Attewell's 2007 study on job discrimination). The shift from Vedic flexibility to post-Vedic rigidity shows how social institutions crystallize over time. For UPSC: connect Ghurye's features to contemporary changes — urbanization loosening endogamy, education enabling occupational mobility, but digital caste discrimination persisting.

QUICK-REVISION CHEAT SHEET

Topic	Main Points (Keywords)	Key Scholars	Examples	Case Studies
Racial Classification	Anthropometry; Cephalic index; dolichocephalic; brachycephalisation; coefficient of racial likelihood; population genetics	Risley (1915), B.S. Guha (1931), S.S. Sarkar (1954), Haddon	1931 Census; Rajputs, Pathans, Marathas; Kaders	Sarkar correcting Guha on Negrito; shift to population genetics
Purushartha	Fourfold path; Dharma = CENTRAL; Artha = righteous wealth; Kama = all desires; Moksha = liberation; Trimarga; Four Yogas	P.V. Kane, Radhakrishnan, N.A. Nikam, Halbfass, Kautilya, Max Weber	SDGs; ESG; Greta Thunberg; civil service ethics; mindfulness; yoga	Yudhishthira-dog (dharma > heaven); Nachiketa (knowledge > wealth)
Varnashrama	Varna = WHAT; Ashrama = WHEN; Grihastha = MOST CRUCIAL; 4 stages; social harmony + personal discipline + spiritual purpose	P.V. Kane, Radhakrishnan, Ambedkar (critique)	NEP 2020; work-life balance; retirement planning; minimalism	Nachiketa; Dhritarashtra-Gandhari (Vanaprastha); Yudhishthira (Sannyasa)
Rina (Debt)	4 debts: Deva, Rishi, Pitra, Atithi; born in debt; karmic bondage; gratitude; Western vs Indic; time-bound vs timeless	Kane, Arvind Sharma, Ambedkar (critique), Feminist scholars	COVID kitchens (Atithi); organ donation (Pitra); climate debt (Deva)	Bhagavad Gita condemning those who take without giving
Karma	NOT fatalism; empowerment; artha-kriya-karitra; Nishkama Karma; tied to rebirth; punya vs papa; self-determined destiny	N.A. Nikam, Radhakrishnan, Halbfass, Weber (critic), Dumont (critic), Vivekananda, P.V. Kane	Gita Ch.2 V.47; conscious choices; natural evolution	Krishna-Arjuna dialogue on action without attachment
Rebirth	Soul persists; linked to karma; Satapatha Brahmana; nirvikalpa samadhi; anatman (Buddhist); opportunity not punishment	N.A. Nikam, Vivekananda, Ambedkar, Ian Stevenson	Climate change as "rebirth of neglected debts"	Advaita (maya) vs Nyaya-Vaisheshika (concrete process)
Caste System	Varna (4) vs Jati (thousands); Portuguese "casta"; Panchamas; Ghurye's 6 features; purity-pollution; 3000 yrs; Vedic flexibility → Post-Vedic rigidity	Kroeber, Ghurye, Dumont, Risley, Graham Chapman, Ambedkar	Segregated colonies; water wells; BR Ambedkar; KR Narayanan	18th century flexibility; Buddhism/Jainism as reform movements
Buddhism & Caste	Rejected Varna; karma & intention > birth; Dhamma; Sangha; Pali; Second Urbanisation; egalitarian; democratized Nirvana	Romila Thapar, Gail Omvedt, Bronkhorst, Ambedkar	Vasala Sutta; Sanchi & Bharhut inscriptions; guilds patronage	Ambedkar's "The Buddha and His Dhamma" = social equality
Jainism & Caste	Sramana tradition; ahimsa; equality of jiva; 5 mahavratas; anekantavada; personal discipline; mercantile community	Paul Dundas, Padmanabh Jaini, Hermann Jacobi	Gandhi's satyagraha; vegetarianism; intellectual pluralism	Paradox: egalitarian theology but caste-like structures in practice

BUILDING BLOCKS — Most Important Scholars & Examples per Topic

Block 1: PURUSHARTHA & DHARMA

Scholars: P.V. Kane (4 dimensions), Radhakrishnan ("principle of right living"), Halbfass (dharma ≠ religion), N.A. Nikam (moksha = river → ocean)

Examples: Yudhishtira-dog story, Gita Nishkama Karma (Ch.2 V.47), SDGs as modern Purushartha, ESG = Artha under Dharma, Kautilya's Arthashastra

Best for: Traditional Indian social system, ethics in governance, Indian vs Western philosophy

Block 2: VARNASHRAMA DHARMA

Scholars: P.V. Kane, Radhakrishnan, Ambedkar (critique: duties tied to birth)

Examples: Nachiketa (Brahmacharya), Dhritarashtra-Gandhari (Vanaprastha), Yudhishtira (Sannyasa), NEP 2020, minimalism

Best for: Structure of traditional society, continuity & change, social organization

Block 3: RINA & REBIRTH

Scholars: Arvind Sharma (duties > rights), N.A. Nikam (rebirth = opportunity), Ambedkar (rejected), Feminist scholars (women's unpaid labor)

Examples: COVID kitchens (Atithi Rina), organ donation (Pitra Rina), climate debt (Deva Rina), zakat/tithe vs Rinna

Best for: Duty vs rights, obligation frameworks, contemporary relevance of tradition

Block 4: KARMA

Scholars: Radhakrishnan ("self-determined destiny"), Vivekananda ("man is maker of his destiny"), Weber (critic: "closed system"), Dumont (karma = basis of hierarchy), Nikam

Examples: Gita Ch.2 V.47, Fatalism vs Empowerment distinction, Nishkama Karma for civil servants

Best for: Philosophical basis of society, fatalism debate, ethics, caste ideology

Block 5: CASTE SYSTEM — STRUCTURE

Scholars: Kroeber (definition), Ghurye (6 features), Dumont (purity-pollution, *Homo Hierarchicus*), Chapman (theoretical vs practical), Risley (criticized)

Examples: Portuguese "casta", Varna (4) vs Jati (thousands), Panchamas, segregation, BR Ambedkar + KR Narayanan, 18th century flexibility

Best for: Caste features, hierarchy, social stratification

Block 6: BUDDHISM & JAINISM vs VARNA

Scholars: Romila Thapar, Gail Omvedt, Bronkhorst, Ambedkar, Paul Dundas, Padmanabh Jaini, Hermann Jacobi

Examples: Vasala Sutta, Sanchi-Bharhut inscriptions, anekantavada, Gandhi's satyagraha (Jain roots), Sangha using Pali

Best for: Social reform, egalitarianism, religion's impact, change & continuity

Block 7: RACIAL CLASSIFICATION

Scholars: Risley (7 types, 1915), B.S. Guha (1931 Census, 6 divisions), S.S. Sarkar (cephalic index, 1954), Haddon (pre-Dravidian tribes)

Examples: Coefficient of racial likelihood, dolichocephalic, Irano-Scythian & Far Eastern (Sarkar's additions), shift → population genetics

Best for: Ethnic & linguistic elements, Indian population classification

Key Texts / Scriptures Mentioned

Text	Relevance
Bhagavad Gita	Nishkama Karma (Ch.2 V.47); condemns consuming without giving
Satapatha Brahmana	First mention of rebirth in Indian texts
Vasala Sutta	Buddha: "by action one becomes a Brahmin or outcaste"
Homo Hierarchicus	Dumont (1970): purity-pollution as basis of caste
The Religion of India	Weber (1958): karma & rebirth as "closed system"
Arthashastra	Kautilya: wealth only when it serves social good
Mahabharata	Yudhishtira-dog story (dharma above heaven)